

Mav and the Arby's Method

Maverick sat on a folding chair in the Clovis community center, his palms sweating. Next to him, the Professor Bucktooth doll was wearing a tiny black turtleneck and a beret.

"Maverick! Do not let the structural pressure of the audition crack your foundation!" the doll hissed. "We aren't just selling roast beef; we are selling the *architectural integrity* of the sandwich! If the curly fry isn't springy, the performance is a lie!"

"I just want to say 'We have the meats,' Professor. It's five words," Mav whispered.

Suddenly, the lights dimmed. A spotlight hit the center of the stage, revealing **Taffy Stamburger** wearing a scarf and holding a megaphone, accompanied by **Cheap Whiskey**, who was wearing a shirt that simply said '*Napping Specialist*'.

"Welcome to the Masterclass, monkes," Taffy rasped. "I am the director. Cheap Whiskey is my creative consultant and chief flavor-tester. If you want that Arby's money, you have to suffer for the art."

"Wait, why are you teaching this?" Mav yelled. "You were just trapped in a Meta Quest yesterday!"

"The digital realm provided me with a profound understanding of interpretive movement," Taffy said dismissively. "Now, Exercise One: **The Sinking Sandwich**. I want you to act like a piece of Swiss cheese that has realized it's being melted on a hot bun. Show me the existential dread of becoming a liquid!"

Mav and the Professor spent thirty minutes sliding around the floor, making "oozing" sounds. Cheap Whiskey walked around, poking them with a yardstick.

"More sadness," Cheap Whiskey commanded. "You're a condiment with no purpose. Think about a world with no napkins."

Mav was about to walk out when the back door creaked open. A tall man with a silver mane of hair and a mustache that looked like it was woven from rugged mountain silk stepped into the room. It was **Sam Elliott**.

The room went silent. Even the Bucktooth doll stopped oozing.

"Now, now," Sam said, his voice sounding like a slow-moving river of gravel and honey. "You boys are overthinking the beef. You're treating the cheddar like it's Shakespeare. It ain't."

Sam reached into his denim jacket and pulled out four incredibly bushy, high-quality **Mustaches**. He handed one to Taffy, one to Cheap Whiskey, one to Mav, and a tiny, custom-made one to the Professor.

"A man—or a beaver—is only as good as his facial hair," Sam drawled. "You want to sell a sandwich? You gotta *become* the sandwich. You gotta feel the horsey sauce in your soul. And if the character won't come to you, you give that mustache a twirl, look 'em in the eye, and you say '**Darn tootin'**.'"

Mav slapped the mustache onto his face. The Professor did the same, looking like a very furry, very aggressive outlaw.

"Now," Sam commanded. "Do the line. Like you mean it. Like you're the foundation of a very delicious lodge."

The Professor Bucktooth doll stood up, twirled his new mustache with a fuzzy paw, and looked directly into the camera lens.

"Darn tootin'..." the doll rumbled, his voice suddenly sounding five octaves deeper. "**WE. HAVE. THE. MEATS.**"

The silence in the room was absolute. Sam Elliott nodded slowly, a single tear of respect rolling down his cheek. "That's it, little fella. That's the beef."

Mav's phone buzzed in his pocket. He pulled it out and saw a text from an unknown number: 'CONGRATS. THE ARBY'S EXECUTIVES ARE WEEPING. YOU GOT THE JOB. BRING THE BEAVER.'

"We did it!" Mav cheered, hugging the sticky doll.

"AHA! THE STRUCTURAL SUCCESS OF THE MUSTAGE!" the doll squeaked.

They celebrated by going to *The Frozen Scoop* for ice cream. Mav got **Meme Mint** again, while the Professor got a cone of **Hickory-Smoked Brisket Swirl**.

As they sat on the curb, twirling their mustaches, they noticed Taffy Stamburger and Cheap Whiskey trying to explain to a police officer why they were still wearing surgical masks and carrying a bag of "Interpretive Sourdough."

"Darn tootin'," Mav whispered, taking a bite of his minty ice cream.

"Toodaloo," the doll replied, his mustache covered in brisket-flavored sprinkles.